Setting Up a Zoho Creator Account and Exploring the Platform Architecture and Interface

Low-Code Application Development

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About This Report

This report captures a first-hand walkthrough of the Zoho Creator account setup process, covering how the platform is organized into Develop, Deploy, and Manage areas. Each screen encountered during the exploration is paired with a plain-language explanation of what it does and how it fits into the overall lifecycle of building a low-code application.

Introduction

- Zoho Creator is a low-code platform for building business applications using drag-and-drop tools and AI assistance instead of hand-written code.
- This report documents a hands-on exploration of the Zoho Creator account setup and its three core functional areas: **Develop**, **Deploy**, and **Manage**.
- Each section pairs a description of a platform screen with a short, simple explanation of what the feature does and where it fits in the application lifecycle.

Platform Architecture Overview

- Zoho Creator has a layered, low-code architecture — from user access down to deployment.
- **Access Layer:** Web Browser, Mobile App (iOS/Android), Customer/Partner Portal, Microservices/API Clients, Embedded Widgets.
- **Presentation Layer:** Pages (dashboards, layouts), Reports (list, Kanban, calendar, pivot), Forms (drag-and-drop data entry).
- **Application & Logic Layer:** Workflow Engine (automation), Deluge Scripting (custom logic), Microservices, Integrations (APIs, payment gateways, marketplace apps).
- **Data Layer:** Cloud Database (multi-tenant), File & Attachment Storage, Audit Trail & Backup.
- **Governance & Security:** Users & Role-Based Access, Security Policies/MFA, Organization Settings, Domains/Active Directory.
- **Deployment & Lifecycle:** Stage Environment, Production Environment, Version History/Publish, Mobile Rebranding/Distribution.
- **Monitoring & Administration** spans the entire stack — Metrics & Analytics, Operations Console (logs, audit, backup), Billing & Subscription Management.

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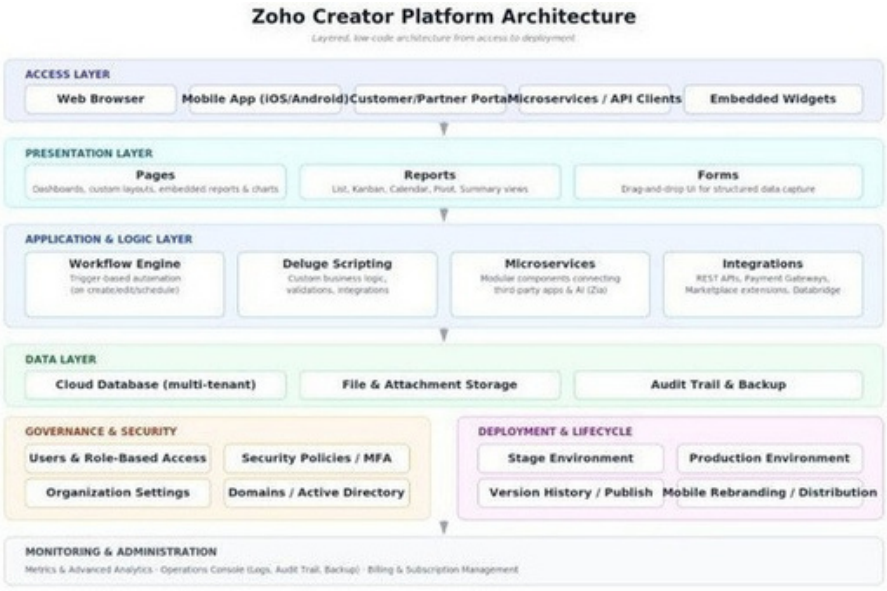


Figure: Zoho Creator Platform Architecture — layered, low-code architecture from access to deployment

Why This Matters

- Thislayered structure lets teams build, test, and scale applications without managing separate infrastructure for each layer.
- Understanding the architecture makes it easier to decide where custom logic, integrations, or security rules should be configured.

1. Develop — Application Dashboard

- Opens automatically after sign-in, under the **Develop** menu.
- Every card here represents a **Solution** — a complete business application created in the account.
- Shows sample apps already created in the account.
- The **"Create Application"** button (top right) is the starting point for building any new app.



Figure1:ApplicationDashboard screen in Zoho Creator

2. Develop — Microservices

- Also found under **Develop**; shown empty if none have been created yet.
- A Microservice is a small, independent, reusable unit of backend logic (e.g., a shared tax-calculation function or authentication check).
- Can be called from multiple Solutions instead of rebuilding the same logic in each app.
- Similar to a function library in traditional programming — write once, reuse anywhere.

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Figure 2: Microservices screen in Zoho Creator

Develop Stage — Additional Notes

- TheDevelopsectionisalsowhereZia,Zoho'sbuilt-in AI, can suggest form fields, layouts, and workflow logic.
- Applications can be built from scratch, from templates, or by importing existing data structures.
- Microservices keep shared logic in one place, so updating a tax rule or validation check only needs to happen once.
- Every element created in Develop becomes available to configure further in the Deploy and Manage stages.

3. Deploy — Environments

- Found under **Deploy**; organizes an application's lifecycle into separate stages.
- Two main environments: **Stage** (for testing) and **Production** (live, used by real users).
- Development = where features are actively built; Stage = where the app is verified; Production = the live version.
- Keeping these separate prevents unfinished changes from affecting real users.

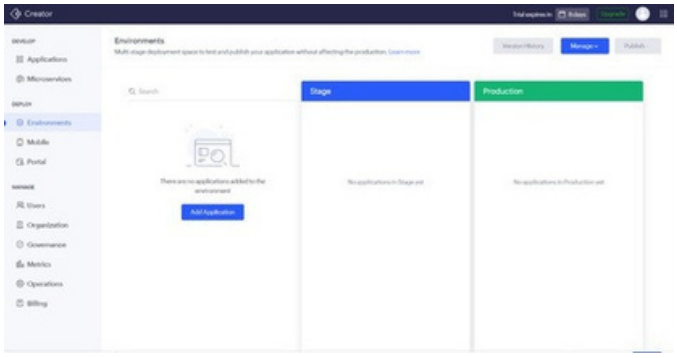


Figure 3: Environments screen in Zoho Creator

4. Deploy — Mobile

- Also part of **Deploy**; automatically adapts an app's layout for phones and tablets — no separate mobile development needed.
- Option to download the app as a branded mobile application or distribute it via Play Store/App Store (requires account upgrade).
- Mobile access is treated as a natural extension of the same app, not a rebuild.

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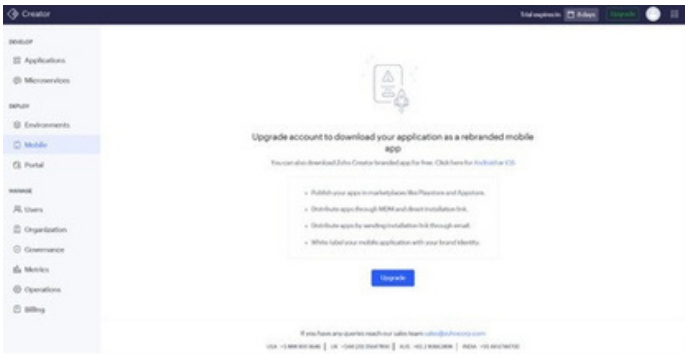


Figure 4: Mobile screen in Zoho Creator

Deploy Stage — Additional Notes

- PublishingtoProduction isadeliberate, manual step, so nothing goes live until it is explicitly approved.
- Version History keeps a record of every published change, making it possible to roll back if an update causes problems.
- The same application logic and data model power the desktop, mobile, and portal experiences without separate coding effort.

5. Deploy — Portal

- The third piece of the **Deploy** stage.
- A Portal gives external users (customers, vendors, the public) a controlled, branded window into the application.
- Does not expose internal data or the full admin interface.
- "Create Now" is the starting point for setting up external-facing access.

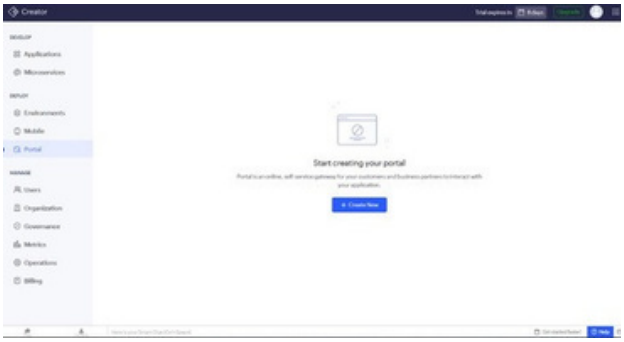


Figure 5: Portal screen in Zoho Creator

6. Manage — Users

- First screen under the **Manage** section.
- Lists everyone with access to the account (e.g., the account owner as an active user).
- Administrators can add, remove, and assign roles/permissions to control access.



Figure 6: Users screen in Zoho Creator

Deploy & Manage — Additional Notes

- APortal canbecustomizedwithitsownbranding,login screen, and access rules, separate from the internal application.
- Roles assigned under Users determine exactly which forms, reports, and actions each person can see or use.
- Keeping external Portal users separate from internal Users helps enforce a clear boundary between public and private data.
- As more people are added, administrators can review and adjust permissions at any time without redeploying the app.

7. Manage — Organization

- Holds company-wide account details: logo, favicon, contact information.
- Includes super-admin details such as email and phone.
- Preferences include organization subdomain and time zone.
- This defines the account-level identity, separate from any individual application.

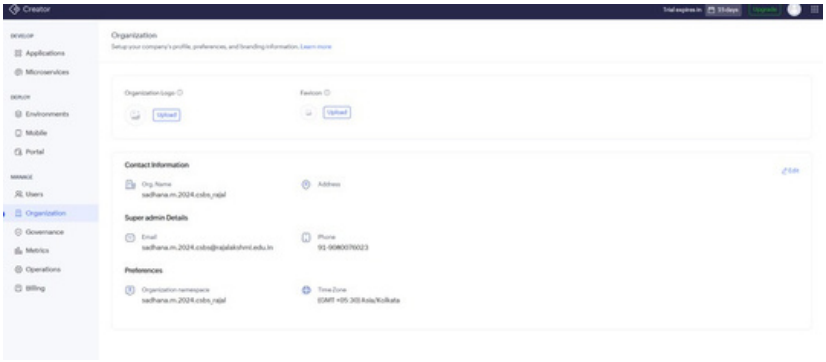


Figure7:Organization screen in Zoho Creator

8. Manage — Governance

- Sets compliance rules, data policies, and audit controls for the account.
- The Security Policies tab lets admins configure settings (like password rules, MFA) that apply across every application.
- Helps keep data handling and access consistent as the account grows.

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Figure 8: Governance screen in Zoho Creator

9. Manage — Metrics

- Tracks usage statistics: applications accessed, live applications, daily average hits per application.
- Includes charts for application access trend and usage summary.
- Gives administrators visibility into adoption and performance over time.

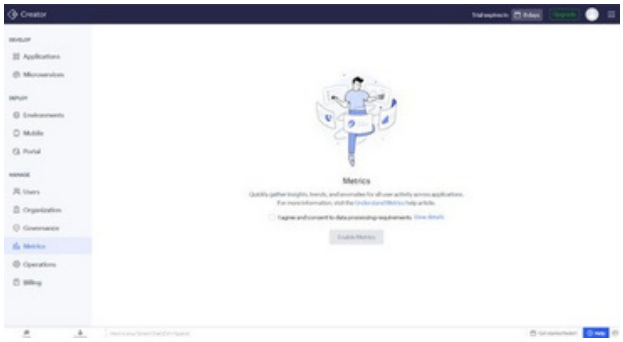


Figure 9: Metrics screen in Zoho Creator

10. Manage — Operations

- Provides advanced, behind-the-scenes management tools grouped under Applications.
- Includes backup, audit trail, domain restriction, API management, logs, publish, form email, and more.
- Also covers support access, system integrations, Zia (AI), payment gateways, and marketplace tools.
- This is the control center for keeping applications running reliably.

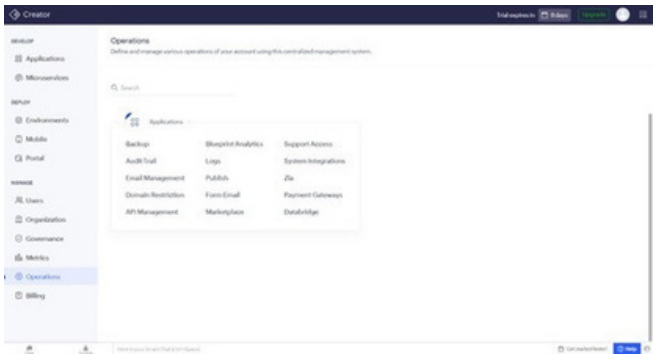


Figure 10: Operations screen in Zoho Creator

11. Manage — Billing

- Gives a comprehensive overview of the account's active subscription.
- Shows plan details such as user limits and app limits, plus an option to upgrade.
- Usage Details section monitors component-level usage, metrics, and custom alerts.
- A useful last step to confirm what the account is entitled to and when action is needed.

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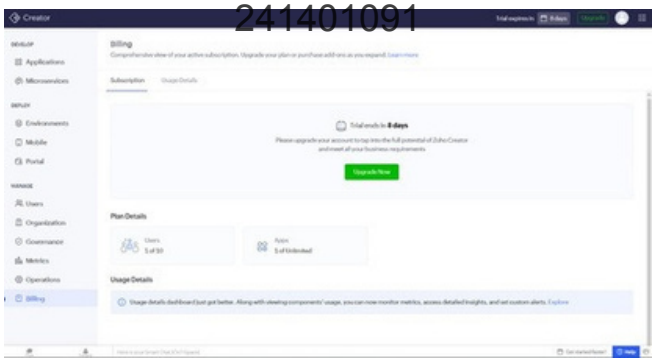


Figure 11: Billing screen in Zoho Creator

Conclusion

- This exploration walked through Zoho Creator's account setup and its three core functional areas.
- **Develop** (Applications, Microservices) — where an app's forms, logic, and reusable components are built.
- **Deploy** (Environments, Mobile, Portal) — governs how the finished app is released and shared.
- **Manage** (Users, Organization, Governance, Metrics, Operations, Billing) — covers the ongoing administrative responsibilities.
- Together, these three areas represent the complete lifecycle of a low-code application, from first build to everyday operation.

Final Note

Thisreport wasprepared as part of hands-on practice with the Zoho Creator platform for the Low-Code Application Development course, based entirely on direct exploration of the account.